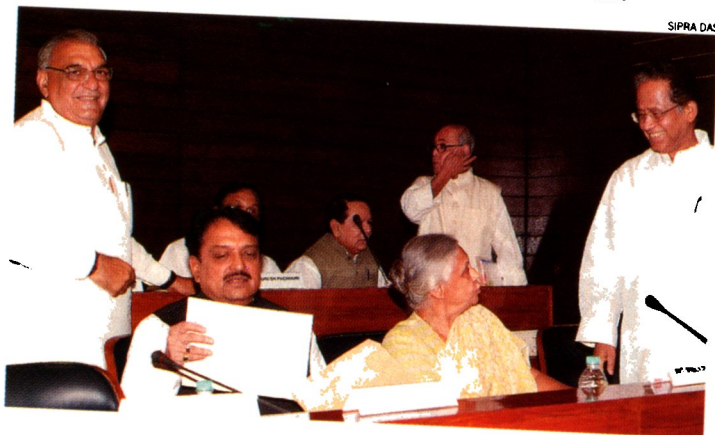


last—try at prime ministership. The leader of the Opposition has been waiting long for this moment and has a well-prepared script ready. His main election plank is internal security and not the hard Hindutva rhetoric that propelled the BJP to power in the '80s. "If voted to power, we shall bring back POTA, recommend Presidential assent for state-specific anti-terror laws and take other tough measures within the first 100 days," he said. And the man who will help him pull his rath to 7 Race Course Road is Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi.

Modi's prominence within Advani's frame of

CURTAIN RAISER: The coming Assembly polls will set the tone for the general elections



SIPRA DAS

security seems a bigger plank than the nuclear deal. This was also clear from the Bangalore meet where there was some lip service to the nuclear sell-out but the main emphasis was on terrorism and inflation. A section of the BJP is wary of attacking the deal because this will go against its middle-class vote bank. Both Advani and BJP President Rajnath Singh have already begun their Vijay Sankalp (determination of victory) rallies all over the country with Modi doing some special appearances. The battle for New Delhi has just begun.

The division of labour within the party seems well defined with Rajnath emerging as the party ideologue. Advani has toned down his soundbites on contentious issues like Ram Mandir, Article 370, Uniform Civil Code and beyond, in an effort to carve out a Vajpayeesque status for himself to keep the NDA allies happy, while Rajnath and Modi will cater to the party's hardline vote bank.

However, it is not going to be a smooth yatra for either the Congress or the BJP, especially with Mayawati and the Third Front on a rampage. Both the national parties know that neither the UPA nor the NDA is in a state to form the next government on its own. So a hunt is on for new allies. The BJP is already talking to Ajit Singh in Uttar Pradesh, Om Prakash Chautala in Haryana and Jayalalithaa in Chennai. However, the local units are

SINCE 2007, THE CONGRESS HAS WON ONLY THREE OF THE 11 ASSEMBLY ELECTIONS WHILE THE BJP HAS WON SIX.



SANJAY RAMACHANDRAN

not happy. The disgruntled murmurings at the party executive prompted Advani to pull out one of his old lectures and admonish the party for its lack of discipline. But even after his stern warning, Uttar Pradesh leader Kalyan Singh criticised the move to woo Ajit.

The Congress too faces its share of dissidence. There is division amongst the grassroot workers in Uttar Pradesh over the proposed alliance with the Samajwadi Party but with Rahul leading the talks, the protests are muted. The West Bengal unit is divided over an alliance with Mamata Banerjee.

Normally pro-Mamata, Information and Broadcasting Minister Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi cautioned that first they should find out which side Banerjee was on—NDA or theirs.

The time for tea and biscuits is over. It is now time for real politick as both sides wipe the dust of their five-year-old manifestoes, coin new slogans and get ready to woo the *aam admi*. The curtain is about to go up for the great Indian circus as the star performers begin to brush up their act.

things has not gone unnoticed within the BJP. Three weeks ago, the duo held a press conference in Delhi to attack the UPA Government's inability to reign in terrorism. The press conference was scheduled for the day the *The Washington Post* broke the US State Department's letter about the nuclear deal. Despite that, the BJP decided to go ahead with the Advani-Modi show and only reacted to the letter much later in the evening. For the BJP, internal